

Bluff

YOUR WAY THROUGH

Motherboards

Motherboards in our computers are reminiscent of *Star Trek*, the TV show from the '70s and '80s. Back then, they looked complex enough for space technology and performed complex operations.

The point we are making is the motherboard is the main man (!) as far as your PC is concerned. Honestly, everything that's involved in running the computer smoothly or enhancing its performance is either part of the motherboard or plugs into it via a slot or a port. It's like the "motherhip" that has all other vital components on it including the processor, memory slots, and many expansion slots for add-ons such as Graphics Card, Sound Card and so on.

A motherboard contains thousands of chips and capacitors that ensure each and every component is getting optimum electric supply from the main power supply for its functioning. This physical construction of chips and integrated circuits on a base is called the "chipset".

Chipsets have various designs; and different systems prefer different designs. Motherboards have come a long way over the last twenty years. The first motherboards held very few actual components. The first IBM PC motherboard had only a processor and card slots.

Here's some more dope to get you through a conversation as an expert: A typical motherboard today would have a PCI (Peripheral Component Interconnect) slot, AGP (Accelerator Graphics Port) slot, North Bridge, Processor Socket, South Bridge, BIOS (Basic Input/Output System), USB (Universal Serial Bus), FireWire and IDE (Integrated Drive Electronics).

Knowing names of motherboards or Graphic Cards by rote is like the MCSE of Geekiness and it would be handy to know "MSI K8N NEO4 Platinum", "ASUS A8V Deluxe" or "ASUS A8N-E". If you can roll these off your tongue, you're good to go!

Festivities And Celebrations

It's been yet another eventful month, and we all have had our share of fun. This time, the editor, Deepak was on a weeklong official tour. And we just stopped short of painting the office red!

The things we did included playing the guitar and humming songs—trust Raaabo and Vijay to perpetually have a guitar stashed away in their cubicles!

Just the other day, in fact, we also tucked into rich chocolate cake—no, it wasn't a birthday; it was Ishan's—our dear CD and DVD dude's—farewell. It's rightly said that parting is such sweet sorrow!

Most of us, Ram, Renuka, Raaabo, Vijay and Preethi in particular, were a happy lot; the reason being we got our machines upgraded—from swanky CPUs and monitors to higher disk space. We wanted more and finally we got more!

Then there was Dussehra. The occasion prompted us to give our

workspaces a revamp—we cleared all sorts of clutter. The *Digit* Test Centre in particular looked incredibly spacious—with all empty product cartons out of the way and the hi-tech gizmos in their rightful places, courtesy TC co-ordinator Gautami badgering reviewers to break away from their tech reverie and remove the sordid stuff for once!

Having the Dandiya Nite right on our premises gave us another chance for revelry. And now, the most awaited annual Diwali party is in the offing! Auditions are in full swing for the same and rest assured that *Digit* members have a few tricks up their sleeves!

As you can see, our relatively unconventional work ethos is accompanied by a rare camaraderie and a fervent passion. Here's wishing you all a very happy, prosperous and safe Diwali from all of us @ *Digit*!

DIGIT DIARY

Prize—the first literary award for "blooks," which, unsurprisingly, are books based on blogs or Web sites. Hey, we didn't even know such books existed. Lulu is "the world's fastest-growing provider of print-on-demand books, including an increasing number of blooks," according to the site.

An FAQ on the Blooker Prize site says, "A blook is a book with content that was developed in a significant way from material originally presented on a blog, Web-comic or other Web site. This material includes the Web site's characters, themes, ideas or outline that end up getting published as a printed book."

The awards—in cash—will be in three categories: Fiction, Non-fiction and Comics. Surprisingly, there's no Poetry category. Each category winner gets \$1,000 (Rs 44,990 approx.). Moreover, the overall winner gets an additional thousand USD!

The FAQ continues: "Scores of blooks have already been published, both by traditional publishers and self-publishers. Indeed, traditional publishing houses, ever in search of the next big-name author, have begun to mine blogs and sites for new talent."

Lulu's site—www.lulublookerprize.com—has attracted a variety of writers. Titles range from "The Authoritative Encyclopedia of Scientific Wrestling"

to "Classroom Blogging: A Teacher's Guide to the Blogosphere" to "How To Cook A Peacock: Medieval Recipes by Taillevent."

Then there's "Cyberchild," described as, "In a war-torn country in Eastern Europe, the life of a young girl is radically changed when she encounters a lab animal freed from a medical experiment gone awry". eBay has to figure and it does: there's "Confessions of an eBay seller."

If these are anything to go by, it's a sad state of affairs for Internet writing. Not to say there aren't any good titles: there's "Metamorphosis of Prime Intellect," definitely worth the time and effort.

While the concept has caught on in the blogosphere, how many takers there are will be known only as the deadline approaches. Some rules for eligibility are also given. Visit the site for more. For now, we'll tell you that the deadline (yes, it's for real!) is January 30 of next year.

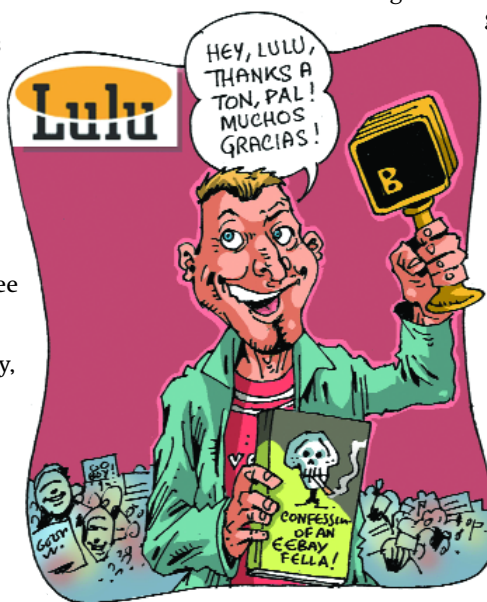


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